Common Ground
Study companion

Evidence notes and an optional written transfer check. This introductory course uses fictional situations to help you explain everyday behavior, examine evidence, and practice applying ideas.

The chapter decks and recorded narration introduce the ideas. These additional notes distinguish general patterns from individual predictions. The written case has no recorded narration. Suggested answers follow the tasks; cover them until you have tried.

Evidence and limits

These are selected sources, not a systematic literature review. Some links provide an abstract rather than free full text. Open introductory readings remain linked in each deck.

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1. The person and the room

Goal: Given an ambiguous action, generate two situational explanations and identify evidence that distinguishes them from a personal explanation.

- Behavior can reflect personal tendencies, circumstances, and their interaction.
- Attribution biases describe tendencies rather than diagnoses of an individual.

When checking your own explanation of someone's behavior, compare repeated observations and plausible alternatives. A single late arrival leaves several causes possible.

When assessing another person's explanation, examine that person's reasons and evidence. A bias label, or your disagreement with the conclusion, does not establish that the reasoning is biased.

- Gilbert & Malone (1995), The correspondence bias (https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/7870861/)
  Review; abstract available

2. The poster that “worked”

Goal: Identify a confound in a before-and-after claim and propose a fairer comparison.

- Random assignment improves comparisons between conditions; random sampling concerns who is selected.
- One before-and-after difference does not isolate a cause; replication and uncertainty matter.

Random assignment helps balance other possible causes on average. It does not guarantee equal groups. Households might share invitations, so one group could be affected by the other group’s message. Assignment also does not make a narrow sample representative. The invented 12-versus-15 attendance comparison does not establish a dependable advantage.

- Open Science Collaboration (2015), Estimating the reproducibility of psychological science (https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/26315443/)
  Replication project; abstract available

3. The story that comes to mind

Goal: Identify a missing base rate and formulate a question that could challenge an initial belief.

- Accessible examples can influence frequency judgments.
- Representative records help distinguish a vivid impression from the underlying rate.

To check your own estimate, compare the cases you remember with a relevant record that includes ordinary outcomes as well as striking ones. A complaint channel can identify faults without showing how common they are.

To evaluate someone else’s estimate, inspect the record they used before proposing a bias. A shortcut can sometimes reflect useful experience; disagreement alone does not settle the question.

- Tversky & Kahneman (1973), Availability: A heuristic for judging frequency and probability (https://doi.org/10.1016/0010-0285(73)90033-9)
  Foundational experiments; access varies

4. The plan we cannot let go

Goal: Distinguish dissonance reduction from evidence-based revision and compare future options without counting irrecoverable costs as benefits.

- Dissonance is a theoretical framework; particular demonstrations need separate evaluation.
- Irrecoverable costs differ from future costs and benefits.

The 2024 multilab study asked people to argue for a position they did not hold, under conditions offering more or less choice. Its primary analysis did not support the predicted attitude difference. That finding concerns the tested procedure, rather than every dissonance claim. Past investments can still matter through future consequences such as usable skills or switching costs.

- Vaidis et al. (2024), A Multilab Replication of the Induced-Compliance Paradigm of Cognitive Dissonance (https://www.psychologicalscience.org/journals/ampps/25152459231213375/)
  Preregistered multilab replication
- Arkes & Blumer (1985), The psychology of sunk cost (https://doi.org/10.1016/0749-5978(85)90049-4)
  Foundational experiments; access varies

5. The quiet vote

Goal: Distinguish normative and informational influence and design a process that makes independent concerns visible.

- Normative influence concerns acceptance; informational influence treats others as evidence.
- Conformity, compliance, and obedience depend on the setting and process.

The classic tasks used particular participants, procedures, and pressures. Their results should not be converted into a universal conformity or obedience rate. Independent judgments and stop rules are practical hypotheses to evaluate in a real group.

- Noba, Conformity and Obedience (https://nobaproject.com/modules/conformity-and-obedience)
  Open introductory module

6. The invitation

Goal: Evaluate a message by its evidence, audience needs, and honest description of social norms.

- Motivation and ability influence how much a message is examined.
- Descriptive and injunctive norms concern behavior and approval respectively.

Central and peripheral processing describe degrees of careful examination, rather than two fixed types of person. The same cue can play different roles: a speaker's expertise might serve as a shortcut or prompt someone to investigate the argument. Clicking, reporting a positive attitude, joining with an informed choice, and continuing to volunteer are different outcomes.

- Elaboration Likelihood Model, Oxford reference entry (https://academic.oup.com/reference/62347/reference-article-abstract/554213168)
  Reference overview; access varies
- Cialdini, Reno & Kallgren (1990), A focus theory of normative conduct (https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.58.6.1015)
  Experimental social-norm research; access varies

7. When "we" takes over

Goal: Identify a plausible group process behind a failure and select a procedure that addresses it.

- Group polarization, social loafing, and coordination loss describe different processes.
- An unfinished task is insufficient evidence that people are loafing.

When reviewing a group's work, distinguish the result from the process that produced it. Poor output alone does not establish low effort, and a poor decision alone does not establish groupthink. Ask what participants did, what information was shared, and which practical conditions constrained the task. The café cases illustrate possible processes rather than diagnosing real groups.

- Karau & Williams (1993), Social loafing: A meta-analytic review and theoretical integration (https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.65.4.681)
  Meta-analysis; access varies

8. The invisible doorway

Goal: Distinguish stereotypes, prejudice, and discrimination and locate a procedural barrier to access.

- Stereotypes, prejudice, and discrimination are distinct, related concepts.
- Contact interventions and procedural changes need outcome-based evaluation.

Contact is not a universal remedy. The 2019 review found gaps in studies that randomly assigned contact conditions and measured particular adult prejudice outcomes. The 2021 review also highlights uncertainty about whether improvements last and extend to other settings or groups. Check the actual people, access, behavior, and later outcomes. An implicit-association score is not a character diagnosis.

- Paluck, Green & Green (2019), The contact hypothesis re-evaluated (https://www.cambridge.org/core/journals/behavioural-public-policy/article/contact-hypothesis-reevaluated/142C913E7FA9E121277B29E994124EC5)
  Review of randomized contact evidence
- Paluck et al. (2021), Prejudice Reduction: Progress and Challenges (https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/32928061/)
  Review of intervention experiments; abstract available

9. A place beside someone

Goal: Explain how contact opportunities and reciprocal responsiveness can support closeness without guaranteeing it.

- Opportunity, familiarity, and similarity can be associated with liking and connection.
- Disclosure and perceived responsiveness can contribute to experienced intimacy.

Repeated exposure does not mean that each extra encounter increases liking. Research combining results from multiple studies finds that the pattern depends on conditions and can change as encounters accumulate. Relationship associations do not establish a guaranteed way to improve a particular relationship, and they never override someone's boundary.

- Montoya et al. (2017), A re-examination of the mere exposure effect (https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/28263645/)
  Meta-analysis; abstract available
- Laurenceau, Barrett & Pietromonaco (1998), Intimacy as an interpersonal process (https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/9599440/)
  Interpersonal-process studies; abstract available

10. Who will do something?

Goal: Identify barriers to helping and design a specific, safe response with clear responsibility.

- Bystander effects depend on danger, relationships, and available support.
- Aggression measures and helping plans require careful interpretation.

Other people can reduce an individual's likelihood of helping in some settings and provide essential support in others. A crowd is not a deterministic cause of inaction. Social-psychology models do not replace emergency training, and laboratory aggression measures are imperfect indicators of serious violence.

- Fischer et al. (2011), The bystander-effect: a meta-analytic review (https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/21534650/)
  Meta-analysis; abstract available

Try a new case

Work without your notes first. Allow about 20–30 minutes. Write your reasoning somewhere private; this page does not collect or grade it. The case is fictional, and different well-supported plans can be reasonable.

The language club

An online language club changes its reminder message. Attendance rises from 14 of 20 members one week to 17 of 20 the next. That second week also has a different lesson topic and a school holiday. The organizer credits the new message.

The organizer opens a planning call by recommending daily homework. Two members agree; others remain quiet. One quiet member privately worries about the workload and assumes everyone else wants the plan. The organizer describes another member's late arrivals as poor commitment without first asking about that member's work schedule.

The club has already paid a nonrefundable fee for a learning app. Some members want to keep using it because of that payment, although a free alternative may meet their future needs. The organizer also worries that switching would make their earlier judgment look poor. Recruitment mainly happens through existing friends. A proposed invitation says that everyone practices daily, but the club has no evidence for that claim.

A newcomer shares a personal difficulty. A member offers advice immediately without asking what support is wanted. Later, a shared resource list remains unfinished because each person assumed someone else was responsible.

Write your reasoning

1. **Separate observations from explanations**

   Identify two observations and two interpretations. For each interpretation, state who holds it. Give a plausible alternative to one interpretation, and name evidence that could distinguish the explanations. What records would you need before judging how common late arrivals are?

2. **Test a causal claim**

   Design a fairer test of the reminder. Specify how you would assign message versions and what you would measure. Could messages be shared between groups? What would a small observed difference leave uncertain, and whose behavior would the result represent?

3. **Explain the group decision**

   Distinguish two reasons a member might publicly agree. Choose a procedure that makes independent concerns visible, and explain why an unfinished task does not establish loafing.

4. **Compare future options**

   Explain how the app payment should enter the club's decision. Identify at least two future consequences that still matter. Separate the organizer's concern about appearing wrong from the members' attention to money that cannot be recovered.

5. **Design an honest, accessible invitation**

   Revise the unsupported daily-practice claim and one access barrier. Specify an outcome you would examine afterward. What would the observed recruitment barrier establish about prejudice?

6. **Support connection and constructive action**

   For the language-club newcomer who shared a personal difficulty, write a response that checks what support they want and respects their choice. Then propose a named role and next step for the club's unfinished resource list. State one thing the case does not tell you about the newcomer's needs or the cause of the unfinished list.

Suggested reasoning

1. Separate observations from explanations

The attendance counts and the reported late arrivals are observations. The organizer's claim that the reminder caused the rise and the organizer's judgment about the late member's commitment are interpretations. Lesson interest, the holiday, or a work constraint are alternatives to investigate. Comparable attendance records or a respectful question about the member's availability could help distinguish causes. Estimating lateness also requires a consistent definition and a record of all comparable arrivals, including those on time; a few memorable late arrivals do not supply a rate.

Revisit chapters 1, 3.

2. Test a causal claim

For the same events, randomly allocate comparable members to invitation versions, keep practical details consistent, define attendance in advance, and account for messages being shared. Estimate the difference and its uncertainty. A small or imprecise result would not prove either a useful effect or exactly no effect. The result would initially concern the tested members, messages, and events; random allocation does not create a representative population sample.

Revisit chapters 2.

3. Explain the group decision

A member may seek acceptance or treat others' responses as information. Collect independent judgments before public discussion and review contrary evidence. The resource list could reflect unclear ownership, dependencies, or missing tools even when effort is genuine.

Revisit chapters 5, 7.

4. Compare future options

The nonrefundable payment is a sunk cost: money already spent that cannot be recovered under the case assumptions. Compare future time, support, switching costs, accessibility, reliability, and learning benefits. Keeping the paid app can be reasonable if its future advantages justify it; switching is not automatically the correct answer. For the organizer, defending the earlier recommendation may reduce discomfort about inconsistency. For the members focused on the payment, treating the nonrefundable fee as a reason to continue is the distinct sunk-cost problem.

Revisit chapters 4.

5. Design an honest, accessible invitation

State a concrete, truthful commitment and available support, with room to decline. Open recruitment beyond existing friends and examine relevant requirements or scheduling barriers. Track who can apply, participate, and remain involved, while protecting privacy. Feeling inclusive or getting clicks is insufficient on its own. A recruitment rule can restrict access without an openly hostile statement. Its consequences do not, alone, establish an organizer's attitude or diagnose the organizer's character.

Revisit chapters 6, 8.

6. Support connection and constructive action

Ask whether the newcomer wants listening, practical help, or advice, and accept the response. Agree on a named owner, a specific next action, support, and feedback for the resource list. General relationship or bystander patterns cannot diagnose an individual's motives or guarantee the plan's success.

Revisit chapters 9, 10.

Assess your explanation

Concept and explanation

Stronger: Names a relevant concept and explains how it could operate in this case, including a competing explanation.

Needs development: Names a concept but gives little explanation or treats a label as a diagnosis.

Evidence and uncertainty

Stronger: Separates observation from inference, identifies evidence that could distinguish competing explanations, and states what remains uncertain.

Needs development: Treats the before-and-after change or a single behavior as proof.

Action and evaluation

Stronger: Proposes a specific feasible action, explains how it could help, and identifies a meaningful outcome and follow-up.

Needs development: Offers a general appeal without identifying responsibility, comparison, or outcome.

Limits and autonomy

Stronger: Uses conditional language, respects stated boundaries, and identifies at least one limit on applying the finding to other people or settings.

Needs development: Treats an average pattern as a guarantee or overrides a person's expressed wishes.

After comparing your work with the suggested reasoning, revise one weak answer in your own words. Revisit the case in about a week using a different setting. This self-check can expose gaps; it does not certify mastery or demonstrate real-world transfer.